

« Every World Cup we go in, there have been heartbreaks. We always believed that we had a bigger role in women's cricket. [Now] Just to read champions beside India's name, it still hasn't sunk in.



EMMANUAL YOGINI

## Smriti Mandhana

**Age:** 29

**From:** Sangli, Maharashtra

Smriti grew up inspired by her brother Shravan, who played for Maharashtra's Under-19 team. At 16, she made her international debut for India against Bangladesh.

**WC25:** Coming into the tournament on the back of a brilliant year with the bat, Smriti took a few games to find her rhythm. Her first half-century came against Australia in the group stage, and from there she didn't look back – registering scores of 88, 109, 34\*, and 24. She finished as India's top run-scorer with 434 runs, breaking Mithali Raj's record of 409 runs (2017) for most runs by an Indian in a single World Cup edition.

**434** runs in 9 innings (HS: 109; Avg: 54.25; SR: 99.08)

« I always enjoy whichever department or situation I am in. As a stage, to perform as an all-rounder, it cannot be a more amazing feeling.



EMMANUAL YOGINI

## Deepti Sharma

**Age:** 28

**From:** Agra, Uttar Pradesh

During one of her regular visits to watch her brother play, her nonchalant direct hit at the stumps caught the eye of former India international and then-chairperson of the women's selection panel, Hemlata Kala. That moment spurred Deepti to take up professional training, and she eventually made her India debut in 2014.

**WC25:** Deepti has consistently proved why she is India's premier all-rounder. She stepped up in the final too – scoring a composed half-century and taking a crucial five-wicket haul. Her all-round brilliance earned her the Player of the Tournament award (22 wickets and 215 runs).

**215** runs in 7 innings (HS: 58; Avg: 30.71; SR: 90.33);

**22** wickets in 9 innings (BBI: 5/39; Avg: 20.40; Econ: 5.52)

## Shafali Verma

**Age:** 21

**From:** Rohtak, Haryana

A ten-year-old Shafali, with short hair, once replaced her brother in a boys' tournament – and went on to win the major individual awards there. A few years later, at 15, she became the youngest woman to make a T20I debut for India. She has since stamped her authority across formats and even captained India to the U-19 Women's T20 World Cup title in 2023.

**WC25:** After Pratika was ruled out of the tournament, big-hitting Shafali was recalled to the ODI squad after a year. While she failed to impress against Australia in the semifinal, she turned the tables in the final, being named Player of the Match for her 78-ball 87 and two match-turning wickets.

**97** runs in 2 innings (HS: 87; Avg: 48.50; SR: 116.86);

**2** wickets in 1 innings (BBI: 2/36; Avg: 18.00; Econ: 5.14)

EMMANUAL YOGINI



« When I saw him [Sachin Tendulkar in the stands], it gave me an incredible boost. I keep talking to him, he keeps giving me confidence. He is the master of cricket, and we keep getting inspired just looking at him.